CHAPTER 42

OVERTAKING BOTHAM

13–17 April 2015

WEST INDIES vs ENGLAND, 1st Test, *North Sound, Antigua*

England 399 and 333/7 dec.; West Indies 295 and 350/7

Match drawn

West Indies 1st innings: **J Anderson 23–9–67–2**; 2nd innings: **J Anderson 24.4–3–72–2**

It's my 100th Test. It's hard to believe the time that has swelled and contracted, on and off the pitch, since Nasser Hussain gave me my first cap. It's a number that I associate with Mike Atherton and Alec Stewart, even a distant memory being David Gower reaching the same mark, three of only a handful of cricketers to have got there in history. They seem like real adults, their achievement born out of careers decades long, legacies already assured. Mine does not feel comparable. It feels as if someone has pulled a band back and then let it go, every Test flashing before my eyes in quicker succession than I have time to grasp.

From the outside, it's hard to judge exactly or understand the wider impact that playing for England this long has had on me. My life has been a series of the same day in different places, being ferried together with the team from one place to the next, complete focus on the job in hand before that gives way to the next. It all blurs into one cartwheeling, endless adventure after a while. Meanwhile, a sense of what it means to stay in people's lives over a period of time has come into view this week. I'm asked about it constantly; told that different parts of people's lives have been experienced through something I've done on a cricket pitch. My